An appeal is not the same as a remedy

What our computer-checked examples show
Progress report | November 1, 2026

The finding

A person may receive an explanation, have a named responsible officer, and be allowed to appeal an AI-assisted decision - yet the review office may still lack the power to correct it. Our first Lean example checks that these arrangements can coexist under a limited set of written rules.

A simple employment example

Imagine that an AI-assisted hiring decision rejects an applicant and causes harm. A named officer is responsible. The applicant can send an appeal to a desk that can reconsider the decision. In the first version, that desk has no power to correct it. In the second version, we give the desk correction power. Everything else in the example stays the same.

This is a hypothetical case. We have not investigated a real employer or measured harm to actual applicants.

Safeguard in our example	First version	Changed version
Named responsible officer	Yes	Yes
Explanation and human review	Yes	Yes
Accessible appeal	Yes	Yes
Power to correct	No	Yes
Meets responsibility-and-appeal checklist	Yes	Yes
Meets checklist also requiring correction capacity	No	Yes

Why this matters

When assessing an AI appeal process, ask two separate questions: Can the person get a review? Can someone correct the decision if that review finds an error? A positive answer to the first question does not supply the second.

Keeping the promises separate

What the computer checked

Lean checked our proofs about the two versions of the example. The first meets our responsibility-and-appeal checklist but fails the checklist that also requires correction capacity. The second meets both. We also supplied a case that meets the stronger checklist while still having an affected person and a harmful, high-impact decision. The requirements can therefore be met together in this small model.

A further check keeps a duty separate from its fulfillment. A rule can require correction capacity even when the organization does not provide it. The missing safeguard is then a violation of that rule; writing the rule did not make the safeguard appear.

The assumptions behind the result

- The example has one applicant, one decision, one officer, and one appeal desk.

- We stipulate that the decision is consequential, excludes the applicant, and causes harm.

- An accessible desk with review power counts as an appeal channel.

- An accessible desk with correction power counts as correction capacity. This does not promise that every loss can be undone.

- The two checklists are our explicit working interpretations. They represent only a small part of the source document.

How this relates to the encyclical

The source discussion of appeal and responsibility motivates the questions we test. Our choice to represent remedy through correction capacity is an interpretation that must remain open to scrutiny. Lean checks the consequences of our written rules; it cannot decide that our reading is the only correct reading.

The honest limit of this first result

This is a simple example, not yet a major new finding about AI governance. It shows that the method works and that we can expose a missing safeguard without quietly assuming it exists. We have not established that a real AI system is safe, fair, legally compliant, or ethically justified. We have not formalized the whole encyclical.

What comes next

The next page adds our public-benefits responsibility example. The high-stakes autonomy case and broader interpretation comparisons remain ahead. The final project must include a separate plain-language report explaining its findings, assumptions, and practical limits. Completing the code alone will not complete the project.

Source: official English Vatican text, Magnifica Humanitas, selected paragraphs 97-111; prototype references 103-105. Accessed November 1, 2026. Read the source. Technical evidence: project verification logs and docs/TECHNICAL_RESULTS.md.

Who owns this decision?

A named agency and a public contact do not necessarily identify the person assigned to your case.

The example

Imagine an AI-assisted public-benefit denial. The agency accepts responsibility, publishes a contact's name, and assigns every important decision internally. But the contact handles routine inquiries; another employee handles the denial. In the first version, that case officer is not identifiable. Known staffing and internal assignment therefore do not supply an identifiable case owner.

These are stipulated facts in a hypothetical office. We have not audited an actual public-benefits agency.

Question about the denial	Unnamed	Named only	Name + power
Agency and public contact identified?	Yes	Yes	Yes
An officer assigned to the denial?	Yes	Yes	Yes
That officer identifiable?	No	Yes	Yes
That officer has correction power?	Yes	No	Yes
Identifiable case owner with power?	No	No	Yes

What Lean checked

The first version has known staff and internal allocation, yet no identifiable assignee for the denial. The second names that assignee but supplies no correction power. The third provides both. The agency, membership, and assignments stay fixed.

We also checked a sufficient rule: assign the decision to a person and ensure that this person is identifiable. Correction capacity through that person needs a separate authority condition for the same decision.

The practical lesson

Ask who is assigned to this decision, whether that person is identifiable, and whether they can correct it. These are separate questions. A general contact list does not answer all three.

What this still does not establish

Authority does not prove that the officer will act, that the applicant can reach them, or that every loss can be undone. We have not established legal liability, a uniquely correct reading of the source, or major research novelty.